

STEM4U — FTC Season Timeline & Team Roles

How the season flows and who does what · BIOBUZZ 2026-27 *Fill in exact dates from FIRST Chesapeake (our region) and your league — dates below are the typical shape, not official.*

The season at a glance

Phase	When (typical)	Focus
Kickoff	September	Watch the game reveal, read the manual, learn the scoring, set strategy
Design & build	Sep-Nov	Prototype subsystems, build the robot, start the engineering notebook
Program & practice	Oct-Dec	Autonomous + teleop, driver practice, reliability
League meets / qualifiers	Nov-Jan	Compete, scout, iterate between events; judging
Regional championship	~Feb-Mar	FIRST Chesapeake championship; advancement to higher levels
All season	—	Engineering notebook, outreach/impact, portfolio updates, Gracious Professionalism

Action: put your league's exact meet dates and the FIRST Chesapeake championship date on a shared calendar now, and work backward — robot "drivable" by the first meet, portfolio v1 two weeks before.

Team roles

A strong FTC team spreads the work — no single hero. Students can hold more than one role, but every role should have an owner.

Drive team (at the field) - Driver 1 / Driver 2 — operate the robot; the most practiced drivers, not necessarily the builders - **Human player** — handles game elements at the field per the rules - **Drive coach** — the only one talking strategy to drivers during a match; keeps them calm

Build & engineering - Build lead + builders — mechanical design, fabrication, maintenance - **Design/CAD** — drawings, iterations, documenting the "why"

Programming - Software lead + coders — autonomous, teleop, sensors, driver controls (Control award)

Documentation & judging - Notebook keeper — logs every meeting (dated), decisions, tests - **Portfolio lead** — builds and updates the Engineering Portfolio - **Judging team** — the students who present in the pit interview

Team operations - Outreach lead — plans and logs community impact (Inspire/Connect) - **Sponsorship/finance** — budget, sponsor outreach, fundraising - **Safety captain** — PPE, battery safety, shop rules - **Parts/logistics manager** — inventory, spares, the pit kit, event packing

A healthy weekly meeting

1. **Stand-up (5 min):** what each sub-team did, what's next, blockers
2. **Work blocks:** build / code / portfolio / outreach in parallel
3. **Test & log:** try it, measure it, write it in the notebook
4. **Wrap (5 min):** what we learned today, goals for next time

The teams that advance aren't just good at robots — they **document as they go, practice driving early, and start outreach in the fall**, not the week before a qualifier.